KEY TERMS

Ambient sound the sounds of everything going on around the person who is speaking

Edit Decision List (EDL) or **Editing Script List** written statement of what is to go in the film and where it is to fit

Editor the person responsible for deciding the order in which shots and sequences are assembled at the post-production stage

Sequence a series of individual shots joined together by the editor

Synchronised sound the words spoken match the lip movements of the speaker

speaker you will pick up a lot of **ambient sound**. Sometimes you will want some ambient sound; if your actors are sitting on a beach you might want to hear the sound of waves and the wind. However, you need to control the level of those sounds so that they do not drown out the voice.

You will almost certainly need to set up shots that are no wider than a medium close-up, because the camera microphone will then be close enough to pick up a reasonable level of sound from the voice. If you are in a noisy environment, such as a busy street, you should move as close to the speaker as you reasonably can.

Using a microphone which is separate from the camera

The advantage of using an external microphone is that you can get it much closer to the person speaking while having the camera set at the type of shot you would ideally like – even if this is a long shot. Professional film crews have someone who does nothing else but record the sound. This sound recordist may use all sorts of different types of microphone, depending on the situation that is being filmed and the effect the director wants to achieve.

Post-production

The individual shots recorded during the production phase only make sense when they are joined together into **sequences**. It may help you to think of this as being like words building up into sentences. Each individual word may have some meaning. When you hear the word 'house' you have some picture in your mind of a building in which people live. But if words are added either side of it, the meaning is much clearer. 'The old house was falling down' gives you a much more detailed image to visualise. And of course if different words are put either side of 'house', the meaning is completely different: 'the glass house shimmered in the sun'. In exactly the same way, if you change the order in which your shots are combined into a sequence, the meaning can change.

Joining together the various shots into sequences is the job of the **editor**. Editing is a vitally important part of the whole film-making process. The director will very often work alongside the editor because the choices made at the editing stage can completely change the meaning of the finished piece.

Edit Decision List or Editing Script List

The first thing to do at post-production is to look at all the material you have shot and start to think about how it will all fit together. You cannot change the type of shot you or your group filmed, but for the edit you have to decide:

- how much of each shot is going to be included in the finished film
- the order in which the shots will be joined together into sequences.

When you have the basic building blocks in place, i.e. all the shots are in the right order and of the right length, then it is time to think of the finer details, such as transitions, visual effects and post-production sound.

Transitions

You get from one shot to the next by means of a *transition*. There are five main types.

- **The cut:** one shot is instantly followed on the screen by another. This is by far the most common transition. It is so common, in fact, that when it happens you hardly notice because you are so used to it.

All the other transitions are much more noticeable, so if you are thinking of using something other than a cut you should ask yourself: *What will that sort of transition add to my film that using a cut would not?*

> **TIP**
>
> If you can access *MediaStage* software, you can practise cuts and other editing techniques.

- **The jump cut:** the effect of a jump cut is to make the character on the screen appear to 'jump' from one place to another. It also makes the person watching jump because it disrupts the illusion that they are watching real life. A jump cut looks more like magic!
- **The dissolve:** the first shot gradually dissolves and is replaced by the second shot. There will be a moment when both shots are on the screen, before the first one gradually fades away.
- **The fade:** this can either be a *fade in*, which is where a blank screen is gradually filled by the incoming shot, or a *fade out* where the shot gradually fades away leaving a blank screen. The fade is usually used to show that, in the case of a fade in, a new scene is beginning, or with a fade out, that an ending of some sort has been reached.
- **The wipe:** the effect of a wipe is to see the first shot chased off the screen by the next shot. Wipes can use all sorts of different patterns to get one shot off and the next on. The incoming shot can burst through in the shape of a star or the outgoing shot can appear to swirl round and disappear like water running down a plug hole. Wipes will definitely draw attention to the fact that you are going from one shot to the next. Only use them if you have a *very* good reason.

Adding visual effects

Once again, unless there is a very good reason, avoid using too many visual effects. You should only use them when you have a clear idea of what effect you hope they will have on the viewer. Common visual effects you could use, if your editing software includes the option, include:

- desaturated colour: this gives a slightly washed out effect to the picture; you can even take out all the colour and make a black-and-white picture
- saturated colour: the colours are very vivid and unnatural
- slow motion
- fast motion.

Post-production sound

There are a few sound sources which you can think about adding to the synchronised sound you will already have recorded.

- **Voice-over sound**: this needs to be dubbed onto any picture sequences. Documentaries and advertisements often use a lot of voice-over.
- **Sound effects** will usually be added to the soundtrack at the dubbing stage. Sound effects can be further sub-divided into two types:
  - Those sounds which directly match actions or events on the screen, for example a door slamming or a glass breaking.

- Those sounds which are about the scene but do not match anything actually shown. For example, the sound of birds singing might accompany a scene set in the countryside, or traffic noise and car horns dubbed onto a scene in a city centre flat. These sound effects are called *ambient sounds*. They appear on the soundtrack to give greater depth to the illusion that what is shown is real rather than something set up to be filmed.

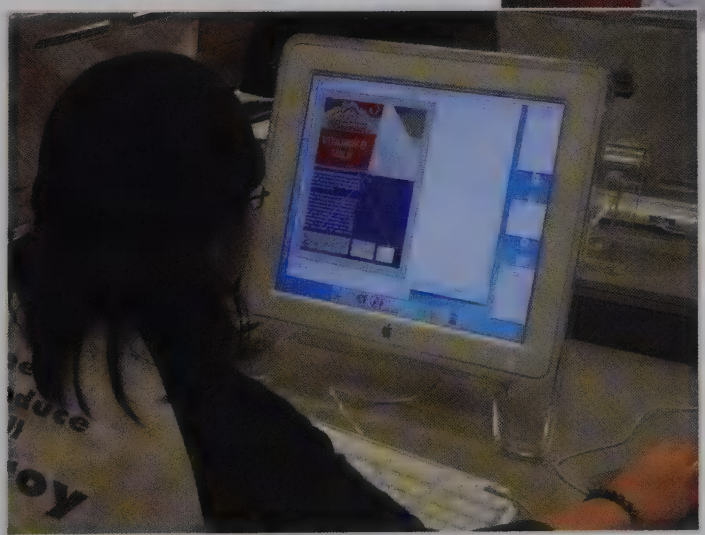
- **Music** is the final sound to be added to your film in post-production. Your choice of music will be very important. Music is used to make the audience feel certain emotions as they watch the action on screen. In high-budget film or television productions, specially composed music will be commissioned for the soundtrack. Alternatively the rights to use well known pop songs can be bought.

The rough cut

With your EDL written, you are now ready to make a *rough cut* of your film. This is a bit like a first draft of a piece of writing. You need to implement all the decisions from the EDL and then sit back and view the rough cut a few times.

Until quite recently, editing was a very time-consuming business, mainly because any changes meant starting from the beginning and editing everything again. With new digital software packages that are cheap and easily available, editing can really become a drafting process.





7 Stages in the production of a video

It is not possible here to give detailed instructions about the process of using editing software because this will be different from one package to the next. If you are not familiar with the way the software works you will need to explore it before beginning your rough cut.

When viewing your rough cut, you need to think about these factors, and write about them in your analysis.

- **The length of time each shot is held on screen:** It is only when you see your rough cut that you will know whether your EDL got this right. If a shot contains one line spoken to camera by your actor then it cannot be shorter than the actual words being delivered. But is there a half-second pause that you could get rid of at the beginning to make the sequence flow more smoothly? Or does the shot end much too abruptly? Maybe an extra half second would make it less rushed? Remember – you can work as exactly as one twenty-fourth of a second so it pays to get the length of shot exactly right.
- **The order in which the shots occur:** Although you may have thought the order was correct when you were writing your EDL, on viewing them you may find that you can change them around, or even lose some altogether.
- **How well any visual effects, music or sound you have added work:** Does the music create the right mood for your film? Are the slow-motion sequences too slow or not slow enough? Do not be afraid to change things and see if they can be made to work more effectively – that is why you made a rough cut.
- **Have you got titles and end credits right?** Often you can leave the design of a title sequence until after you have viewed the rough. The same will be true for the end credits. But you will need to make sure everyone who has worked on or helped in the making of your film gets a mention.

The fine cut

Now that you have made all the notes on the changes to be made, you are ready to return to the editing software and make the final version – the fine cut – of your film.

Making a radio programme

In comparison to video-making, recording an audio product is potentially a much simpler process. It is possible to produce almost broadcast-quality results with relatively inexpensive equipment.

The type of recording gear you use will probably be dictated by the resources your school can provide. These days most radio stations use digital equipment, so interviews will be recorded on mini-disc players which slip into a journalist's coat pocket. But not long ago they were still recording on audio cassettes or open spool tape. Even if you only have access to audio-cassette machines, you can still make a radio programme which sounds pretty much like the real thing.

Pre-production

Once you have completed your research you will need to write a programme outline and then a running order of the items which are to appear. It is important to show that you can use a full range of audio sources. Making a 'top ten' music hits tape, with you as the DJ, may be easy but it will not challenge you very much. If you are making a radio programme you should think about a 5–10-minute section of a radio-style